Deep Tech — when the product is still in the lab

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What changes: your riskiest assumption may be technical — but the commercial clock still runs. You validate demand for the OUTCOME before the tech is ready, exactly like Dropbox validated with a video.

Your wallet-equivalents (honest hierarchy): paid feasibility study/pilot from an industrial partner (best — real money) > LOI with concrete numbers and conditions (good — conditional wallet) > EXIST/grant awarded (money, but a jury is not a customer — label it) > “strategic interest” emails (signal only). The revenue bars: one €3k paid feasibility study can clear multiple weekly bars — deal size compensates count.

Your ladder translation: M04 landing page: a technical one-pager + outcome demo video sent to 20 named industry contacts, threshold on meeting-requests. M06 prototype: simulation/benchmark that proves the CLAIM: build the smallest thing that tests the physics. M07 monkey-first is your module — name the assumption that kills it. M08: a paid feasibility study counts. An LOI with numbers is signal until money arrives (framework 03, question 7). M09: a fixed-scope feasibility study at a list price, ordered through a form that issues the invoice. M10 retention: a paid pilot that turns into a follow-on order is your “paid again”. Agree its success criteria before the pilot (Module 09). M12: your funding path skews grants/strategic (Celonis started on EXIST).

Your traps: “we’ll validate after the paper”, grant-chasing as revenue substitute (two grants is not PMF), pilots that never convert because success criteria were never agreed (agree success criteria before the pilot, Module 09).

Kill criteria that bite: no industrial partner will pay even a token feasibility fee after the number of asks you set before the test · the technical monkey fails its own benchmark twice · every “customer” wants it free until it’s perfect.